

HANDOUT 1: Objective Observation vs. Opinion

Reference and practice activity for training participants.

What Is an Objective Observation?

An objective observation describes exactly what a child does or says — using factual, specific, measurable language. It includes who, what, when, where, how often, and how long. It does not include interpretations, assumptions, or judgments about the child's motives or character.

What Is an Opinion or Interpretation?

An opinion or interpretation goes beyond what can be directly observed. It assigns meaning, motive, or a label to the child's behavior. Opinions in documentation can be harmful — they can label children unfairly, undermine family trust, and create legal liability.

Side-by-Side Examples

Commonly Used Word	Instead of:	Write this instead:	Why it matters:
Aggressive	He's so aggressive.	When a peer took his block, Marcus pushed the peer and yelled 'mine!' The push lasted 2 seconds.	Describes the observable action without labeling the child.
Lazy	She's lazy and never tries.	During writing time, Amara put her head down for 8 minutes. She did not pick up her pencil when given the direction.	Describes what happened, not what the provider thinks about the child.
Hyper	He's hyper and can't sit still.	During the 15-minute circle time, Elijah left his spot 5 times. He returned with one-to-one adult support.	Provides specific, observable data.
Defiant	She was being defiant again.	When given the clean-up direction, Sofia said 'no' and continued playing. This occurred 3 times over 5 minutes.	Removes judgment and describes the behavior and its duration.

Spoiled	He's so spoiled.	When told it was another child's turn, Liam cried for 6 minutes and said 'I want it!' four times.	Avoids family blame and focuses on what occurred.
Does not listen	She never listens.	When given a 3-step direction, Ana completed step 1 and then began playing. She did not complete steps 2 or 3.	Specific and observable — useful for planning support.
Sensory issues	He has sensory issues.	During art, Carlos pulled his hands away from the paint and said 'yucky' four times. He asked to wash his hands.	Describes what was observed without diagnosing.
Delayed	She seems delayed.	During a 30-minute free play period, Nadia communicated using gestures and 3–4 single words. She did not use two-word phrases during this observation.	Provides data that can be documented and shared with specialists.

Practice Activity

Rewrite each opinion statement as an objective observation. Use specific, factual language.

1. *"She always has a meltdown."*

Rewrite:

2. *"He acts like a baby."*

Rewrite:

3. *"She's manipulative."*

Rewrite:

4. *"He's a problem child."*

Rewrite:
